Interview Questions – Part B: Open-Ended Qualitative Questions (50 minutes)

Now, I would like to ask some questions to understand your experiences with buying and preparing food and using food assistance programs (such as SNAP or food stamps, food pantries, and school lunch programs) and how refugee organizations have helped you with food.

Questions on food and nutrition insecurity experiences and using food programs (40 minutes)

1. Tell me about your experience in buying and preparing food for your household in the U.S.

   Follow up: Where do you usually get your groceries?

   Like Smiths or Walmart, Costco.

   Follow up: do you get them in bulks and stuff?

   Yeah

   Follow up: What do you buy when you go?

   Most like beverage, and meat usually.

   Follow up: Do you eat rice and pasta?

   I get those from Chinese, the rice.

   Follow up: Do you have any cooking appliances, do you have like a pot or pan for you to be able to do all your cooking and stuff like that?

   Yes

   Follow up: Do you know how to cook?

   Yeah, I used to work for restaurants. I used to work for wendys and sbarro.

2. Review answers in the Food Insecurity sections and ask the following questions if they have experienced food insecurity in the last 12 months; if not, go to question #3:
   a. You indicated that you often/sometimes had problems with food in the last 12 months, can you tell me more about that?
      Follow up: Did you ever run out of food?
      The food I like to eat yes.
      Follow up: Did you always have something to eat on the dinner table?
      Sometimes not what I prefer to eat
      Follow up: do you prefer your own cultural food?
      My cultural food, yes
      Follow up: Did you find it hard to make your own cultural food or make it?
      It seems like they have all kind of stuff that we used to eat back home, Some of the stuff now there is this summer, I can get at the farmers market, you can get fresh vegetables the same we

ate back home. But once you hit the winter you can't get those so you have to eat something different like spinach.

Follow up: So you have to eat more domestic vegetables like winter vegatables rather than the vegetables you like from home?

Yes

Follow up: You explained that you get foods from the farmers market, has there been a situation now or in the past where you found it difficult to find food?

Any type of food? No

b. Can you explain how your <IRC> helped you with food?

Yeah, they used to bring food here a few years ago, not too long ago, a couple years ago, so they used to bring cooked food and canned food and those kinds of stuff.

Follow up: So they used to deliver food to your house? was that helpful?

Yes, yes it was helpful

Follow up: Do you think sometimes that its hard for you to go grocery shopping because you work a full time job?

No, I usually stock to last for about a week

Follow up: So you have a day in the week to go shopping?

Yes

i. Explore training on budget management, preparing meals, purchasing foods, using food pantries and farmers markets, and applying for food programs such as SNAP.

ii. What has been most useful to you among things that your <IRC> do?

They did a lot for us, I cant explain it a lot. They are still doing a lot of stuff for us so like we have a garden, so they help us prepare those stuff. And they are still doing that. We used to have a community board, which we don't have anymore I don't know what happened. They help us send a post and stuff. They help us a lot of stuff and they tell us a lot of stuff. (They help you out in a lot of ways?) yes a lot of ways and they are still doing, and they are still doing.(They are still helping as much as you need?) Yes but it is not the same like the past. In the past we were more participating but now the employ keep changing. (your caseworker changes?) Yes, but I do not have a case worker anymore. (So in the past the employ would change and so would the quality of help?) Yes

c. Can you tell me when food became a problem?

No no really, its the only thing that I get problem with is the meat, and which is what I eat.

Follow up: And you find like you find it hard to find meat or to afford meat?

Afford But thats why a lot of refugees mortgage a lot more expensive, some people they cant eat food and stuff. Ive been telling people most people nowadays only buy like things they can afford, stuff that is not

too expensive and they can eat for at least a few days. Like people in the community tend to buy rice beans and flour and potatoes. Those stuff can last for a while. When it comes to meat, vegetables, its not easy to afford.

Follow up: do you find that people buy those (meat and fresh vegetables) for special occasions rather than basic necessities?

Yes yeah

Follow up: Do you find that some people buy meat for special occasions rather than day to day use?

Yes.

d. Review answers in the Utilization section and ask the following questions if they have NOT used SNAP/WIC/NSLP/Food Pantries/Other programs in the last 12 months:
    i. You indicated that you often/sometimes had problems with food in the last 12 months. Can you tell me why you have not used food assistance programs during these times?

Im not qualified for that. Every time I go apply for those assistant, they look your income and they will say your income is high. But they dont look like how much you are spending. You gotta your mortgage, you gotta use the cash for hygiene kits and stuff like that. If something is broken you gotta pay cash. But they dont look that way. They say your income is high. (They are not looking at the way your income is distributed, they are just looking at the income itself?) That is not how it should be. If you are applying once or twice and then you wont get it, then they say your income is too high, you just give up. And I dont have time to fight them.

Follow up: so you have applied multiple times?

Yeah, and its kind same thing. Kids like this. You know hospital is expensive. They dont have no medicaid. So now you're stuck with bill, maybe you pay extra 500 dollars a month. But they dont look at that stuff either. Like here I had a sewer broke down, now I ended up paying 500 dollars extra a month to pay off. But they dont look at that, thats why you go and apply, state looks at that, they come and go and theres nothing you can do.

Ask those who are still receiving <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> support: Have you asked your <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> to help you because they help refugees find food resources?

I did sometimes, during holiday season. Sometimes i go get some stuff like urgent things and some canned food.

Follow up: do you get it from IRC?

Yes

Follow up: are they foods you can keep for a long time?

Yes

i. Ask those who graduated from <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY>: Can you explain your experiences with applying for food programs since you graduated from <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY>?

(Graduated from CCS)

When I became a citizen, I had to apply to IRC. So I was doing to both.

well it wasn't that hard back then. I was a student and I was getting food stamps. So it wasn't that hard.

Follow up: Do you have like the resources you need to be able to do it at home and stuff like a computer and stuff?

No, I didnt have a computer. Sometimes Id use a library or school computer.

Follow up: do you feel worried using a library computer?

No, they would give you like an hour. Some of those applications could get done in about half an hour.

Follow up: do you still do that (go to the library computer) to do applications and stuff?

I have a computer now

Tell me about your experience in finding and buying foods from your culture.

a. How important eating foods from your culture is to you?

it is very important, you know. Finding something I used to eat here in this country, i was not expecting having that stuff in this country. We were expecting american food because they dont have our cultural food. When we went to the store, we were surprised. They have some stuff that we used to have back home.

Follow up: what kind of cultural foods do you guys eat?

Mostly the fufu and soup, and rice. Eating rice in my country you were a like a boss, rice was very expensive and hard to find. We usually eat rice during the holiday season. In those special occasions, but now in this country, its easy to get rice. So mostly what we eat is the fufu and soup and rice and potatoes and stuff.

Follow up: do you have the occasional protein like a meat or anything like that?

Meat, back home, you have to be rich. Meat and fish, it was hard to get. Because it was expensive. In my country, this country meat is expensive. (So you kinda eat more vegetarian?) mostly we are vegetarian and mostly beans. Those kinds of stuff easy to find and cheaper to buy. Where do you get your vegetables and cultural foods from? Walmart, smiths

i. How does/did <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> help you with finding foods from your culture?

i. What did they do that was the most helpful and why?

Yes, because most caseworker, they were from different countries, so they know what store they would take us to find.

Follow up: did they take or did they tell about it (the stores)?

Sometimes they would take us, we didnt have a car, so we didnt know where to go. So as it will pass a few months, sometimes we find the people already here in this country from our country, and they help us.

i. (So you kinda find your own little community and they help you?) yes

ii. Do you use Farmers Market to buy foods from your culture?

I do sell some stuff too. Mostly vegetables, mostly eggplant and african corn. I grow my own vegetables. In the winter, i end up buying (vegetables) from walmart or smiths. But now because its farming season, we dont farm in the winter so thats when I have to go buy them. Tomato season wasnt well, so im gonna end up having to buy tomatoes

i. Have you used the Sunnyvale Farmers Market (4013 S 700 W)?

ii. if yes, how did you hear about it and what has been your experience with that?

Yes, thats been going for like more than 10 years. We heard that from IRC.
Well you get to meet new people, different cultures, and their preference. Thats been about it mostly you meet new people from different countries.
(Has it been a good experience?) Its good. You know when you from different country you come to a different country, of course you are gonna face different challenges. We didnt we were gonna be able to do a lot of stuff we are able to do right now. We didnt know we will have a car. We didnt know we would be able to speak english. Theres a lot of stuff we didnt know we would be able to get to it. I got this opportunity to come to this country, i need to work hard

Can you describe your experience with the New Roots program (also known as IRC Garden or IRC Farm Program)?

Yes, ive been working with them, first i was with my parent. (For you to sell your vegetables?) yes , so there was the whole set up the whole system.

Follow up: do you ever get anything from them, like receive food from the new roots program?
That was a part of what I used to get back in the day. I would say yes. (What about now?)
No, now I do farm. I told them to stop. So they bring vegetables which I farm them, I told them to stop. I told them to stop since I dont have space.

Suggestions for future strategies to improve food access (10 minutes)

READ TO PARTICIPANT: This is the last section of our interview and I would like to ask your suggestions on how to improve food security among refugees.

1. What do you think keeps people from your community from using food assistance programs that are available to them?

My own experience, i dont know how other people would do it. Like me I have a freezer where I can keep my stuff that can last for like a year, til the next farming season. Thats how I keep my stuff, so that keeps me from going to ask for food. I have alot of freezers in the garage.

Follow up: do people in your community use food stamps and stuff?

They do

Follow up: what about the people who need them but dont use them?

I dont think anybody who has them dont use them. They all use them.

Follow up: so you think everybody is aware of like the ability to get food stamps and stuff like that?

Its to use them. If they had that chance to get them. A lot of people they will apply but they will end up not getting them. So it means they are not able to buy all the nutrition they need. So I dont know, they look at so many stuff now to get qualified for that, especially the one as I said the income and stuff like that

2. How do you think we can ensure that refugees can access food assistance programs when they need help with food?

They need to increase the minimum amount in order to qualify for food stamps and stuff. Like for example they need to check how much that persons paying the mortgage and also instead of looking at your income too high. Yes if the income is too high but theres other stuff that person need to cover.
If you look at how much I make a month, yes thats okay. But Im spending all that even end up going in the negative in the account.

3. What do you think <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> and other refugee organizations can do to ensure refugees have enough food?

   I dont know what IRC could do better. What they did, they wanted everybody to be able to grow their own vegetables during the farming season. Like for example, when you are starting, they will give you a small bed to farm my own vegetables. They wanna see if you are able to keep up with that. If you are able to keep up in the next season, they will give you a big land to grow your own stuff. Thats a good help, they helping in different ways for refugees to be able to have enough food. I dont see other ways they will be able to help refugees. Also its good if they give refugees different resources if they need food or that kind of stuff that can get access for it. Or hygiene kits or that kind of stuff that will help refugees put the money they make into other stuff in many ways. That's what IRC has done. They have been trying to help the refugees. So they be able to grow their own vegetables that way they can cut up money for their needs.

4. Do you want to share anything else regarding your experiences with food insecurity and using food assistance programs since you moved to the U.S. and since you graduated from <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY>?

   No I think I answer most in this.